The Crate at Warehouse 4

Example Author

The Eastern Gate

Mara stopped beneath the quay lamp. Someone had tried the eastern gate of Warehouse 4. Fresh scratches crossed the lock, and an abandoned crate stood beside the wall.

Along the harbour, the windows of the bonded warehouses held the last light of the evening, while the water below carried small pieces of timber towards the mouth of the basin. A cart stood beneath a loading crane with its shafts resting on the wet cobbles. Beyond it, a row of closed shutters reflected the lamp in narrow strips of yellow.

The night watchman asked her to wait. Beyond the quay, a small launch disappeared into the mist. She could hear its engine long after its lights had vanished.

By dawn, the crate would reach the customs station. Mara stayed behind to write down what she had seen, leaving the officer to explain what the crate contained. In her coat pocket, a folded delivery receipt pressed against the notebook she had brought from the office.

The Loose Board

A board moved. Mara turned. The crate tipped towards the drain. She caught its corner and pushed. Her boot slipped. Water entered her shoe. The watchman reached the other side. Together they set it flat.

Something rattled inside. A nail stood proud of the lid. Mara pulled her hand away. Blood marked the wood. The watchman lifted his lamp. Its light crossed a torn strip of paper, an empty patch where a label had been, and a length of cord caught beneath the lid.

Footsteps sounded behind the gate. Mara held up her hand. The watchman stopped. Another step. Then silence. She moved away from the wall. A shadow crossed the lamp. Ivo came round the corner, carrying a coat over his arm.

He put it down. The three of them dragged the crate clear of the water. One plank cracked. The watchman fetched a wedge. Mara kept both hands against the lid until he returned. Nobody opened it. Across the basin, the launch's engine faded. Ivo looked towards the sound, but the mist had already closed over the water.

Questions on the Quay

"Did you see who left it?" Hansen asked. He had come from the customs station with a pencil, a small book and a length of sealing cord.

"I saw two people by the gate," the watchman said. "When I called, they ran towards the basin. I stayed here."

"Were they carrying anything?"

"Not when I saw them. The crate was already beside the wall."

Hansen turned to Mara. "And the launch?"

"I saw its light. I heard the engine after the light disappeared. I couldn't see anyone aboard."

"So you cannot say they reached it."

"No. I can tell you which way they went. That's all."

Ivo lifted the coat from the ground. "The foreman wants to know when we can use the gate. There's a cart waiting at the other end."

"When I've finished recording the lock," Hansen said. "Keep the cart there for now."

Mara showed him the cut on her hand. "That happened when we moved the crate. The mark on the lid is mine."

Hansen wrote it down. He asked her to repeat the order of events, and this time she began with the loose board rather than the disappearing light.

The Customs Note

On the evening of 14 October 1923, an attempted entry at the eastern gate of Warehouse 4 was reported by the night watchman. Scratches were recorded on the external lock. No conclusion about the implement used was entered at the scene.

A wooden crate stood beside the warehouse wall. It was moved clear of the drain after a loose base board shifted. One lid plank cracked during that movement. A small blood mark on the lid was attributed to a cut sustained by Mara while handling the crate.

The watchman reported two people leaving the gate area towards the basin. Mara reported a launch light and an engine heard from the same general direction. Neither account established that the people boarded the launch.

The crate was sealed and transferred to the customs station at dawn. Its contents were recorded there as untaxed tobacco. This note separates observations at the quay from the later inspection. The statement that the launch carried the tobacco was not supported by the observations available to the officer.

The Blank Line

Mara read her account beside the office stove. In the first version she had written that the smugglers escaped by boat. The sentence seemed to gather the whole evening into a useful shape: two figures, a crate, an engine in the mist. It also joined things that nobody had seen together.

She crossed it out. On the next line she wrote what the watchman had told Hansen, followed by what she herself had heard. The gap between those statements made the page look unfinished. She left it there.

Her father had kept a notebook for the small repairs he made to fishing boats. He recorded the part replaced, the timber used and the day the same leak returned. As a child, Mara had found the repeated entries dull. Now she remembered how often he had refused to write that a boat was sound merely because the water had stopped coming in.

Ivo set bread beside the notebook. He asked whether she had finished. Mara looked again at the blank line. There was nothing more she could put there without borrowing somebody else's certainty.

Morning Handover

By morning, the crate was gone. The customs cart had left pale tracks through the mud, and a new seal hung from the warehouse gate. The torn label remained in Hansen's envelope. The quay looked almost as it had before the watchman called.

Mara handed the delivery receipt to the foreman. He checked the cart number, asked when the gate had reopened and entered the delay in his ledger. He did not ask about the boat. For his work, the waiting time was the part of the night that still needed an explanation.

Hansen returned her notebook. He had marked the point where her account ended and his inspection began. The contents of the crate belonged to his report; the light disappearing into the mist remained in hers. Neither page supplied the missing journey between the two.

At the basin, Ivo waited beside the empty cart. Mara put the notebook away and took the other shaft. Together they turned towards the open gate. Behind them, a bell sounded from somewhere beyond the warehouses, clear for a moment in the lifting mist.